Afghanistan and the Horn of Africa. Huang agreed about the need to improve India relations, but also wanted the US to do more for Pakistan, adding that Washington's traditional approach of giving more attention to India was not "appropriate."[162]

Meanwhile, Sino-Indian rapprochement seemed to stall. In April, Vajpayee had listed "some movement" in China relations as one of the achievements of the government's first year, while stressing the need for "equality and reciprocity."[163] But the Chinese Vice Foreign Minister Han Nien-Lung publicly stated that India was not moving "fast enough" and had not taken any "positive action." Huang had also mentioned to Brzezinski that India had not set a date for the Vajpayee visit. Among the sticking points was the border problem, which Beijing wanted to put on ice while discussing other issues.[164] It is not clear if there was a link, but after the Brzezinski-Huang conversations, the vice president of the National People's Congress said that it was possible to consider parallel border talks and normalization talks with India.[165]

That June, Desai traveled to Washington. Ahead of that visit, Oksenberg urged Carter to "strongly encourage" the prime minister to send Vajpayee to China as soon as possible. He felt that Moscow was causing the delay.[166] When Carter and Desai met, they discussed their respective reconciliation efforts with China. The Indian prime minister said he found the more "outer-minded" Chinese attitude since Mao's death "better." Sino-Indian relations, he admitted, remained "bad," but "we would like to be friends" and "must settle the border issue." He said the atmosphere was "clearing up," and noted that China had adjusted its position on border talks. He acknowledged the Chinese complaints that Vajpayee's trip was taking too long to schedule, but noted that the foreign minister would likely go after the Indian parliament's monsoon session. That evening, exchanging toasts with Desai, Carter praised the prime minister's efforts to improve relations with China.

The president, on his part, told Desai that the US was going to start negotiations on normalization with China "very shortly." The premier expressed concern about the American willingness to sell potentially dual-use equipment to Beijing. He also cautioned, if "you give up Taiwan. This would be a breach of trust." Carter's response was less categorical than in January. He said that it was not an easy subject and added, "We are not